DARG
Dog Walker

Designing a digital coordination layer where the rescue dog is the ultimate client.

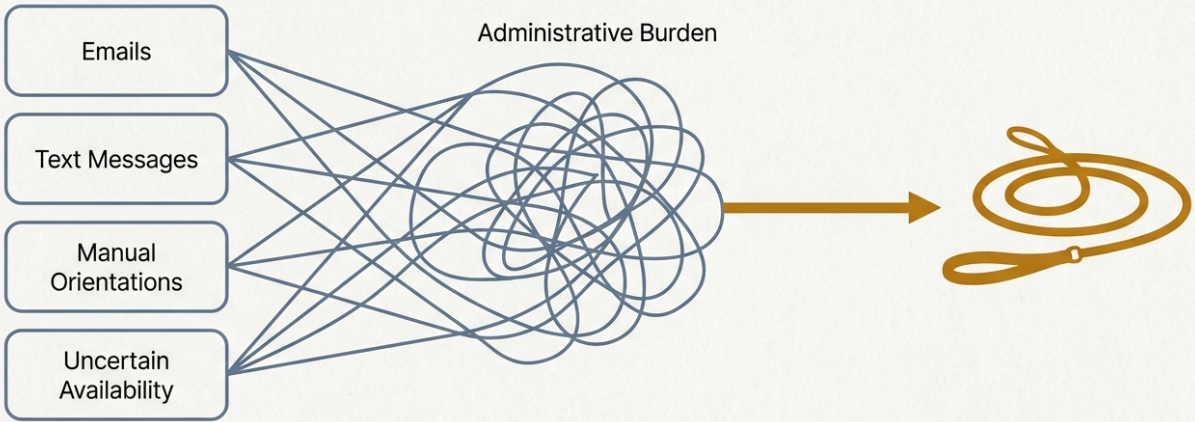
A functional prototype for DARG (Domestic Animal Rescue Group, Hout Bay, Cape Town) transforming volunteer scheduling into a manageable, repeatable service that prioritises animal welfare above all.



Gemini Notebook

Who suffers when operational systems fail?

Coordinating people, dogs, availability, and recurring walks is deceptively complex. When scheduling becomes an administrative burden, rescue dogs miss out on vital walks and socialisation. The solution is not just another booking interface, ing interface, but a shared operational picture.



Gemini Notebook

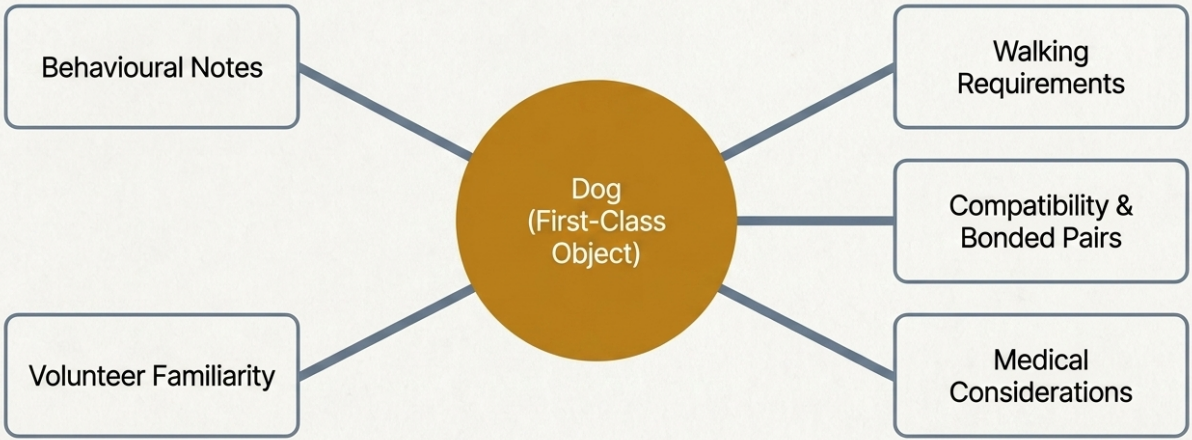
	Commercial Dog Walking App	Rescue Operational System
The Client	The paying customer	The dog's welfare
The Model	Strictly 1:1 transactional bookings	One volunteer → multiple dogs → one scheduled activity
The Goal	Maximise booking volume	Create predictable, recurring routines for anxious animals
Oversight	Peer-to-peer ratings	Centralised administrative control and compatibility tracking

Standard tech fails rescue dogs because it serves the customer.
A true rescue system must serve the animal.

Gemini Notebook

The Paradigm Shift: Dogs as First-Class Objects

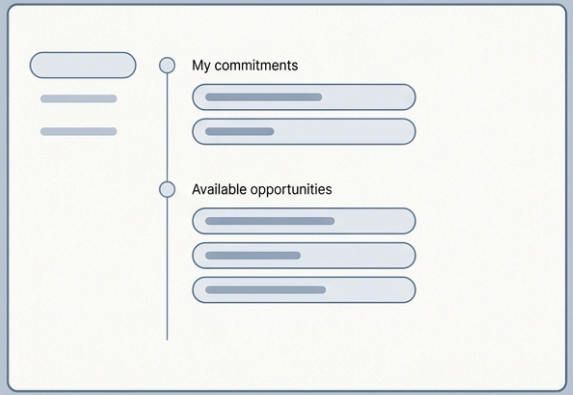
The foundational architectural decision: dogs are not simply text labels attached to calendar entries. By placing the dog at the centre of the relational database (Volunteer ↔ Dog ↔ Walk), the system creates a protective, central source of truth for every animal.



Gemini Notebook

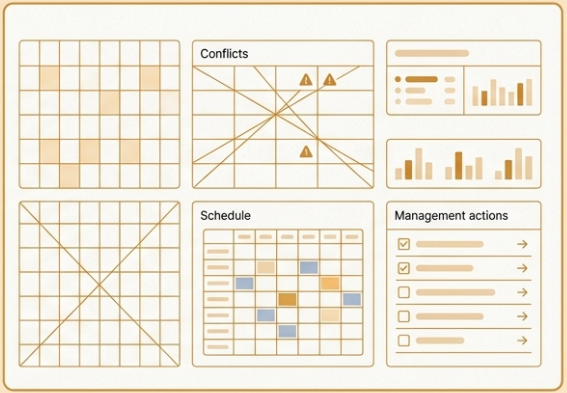
Protecting the Animal via Role-Based Access

Mental Model: “When can I walk a dog?”



Welfare Benefit: Radical simplicity removes friction, encouraging higher volunteer participation and more walks for the dogs.

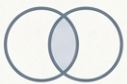
Mental Model: “What is happening across the organisation?”



Welfare Benefit: Absolute operational control ensures safe matching, prevents dogs from being overlooked, and maintains shelter protocols.

Gemini Notebook

Interface Design as Animal Advocacy



N-to-N Booking Architecture

Benefit: Allows volunteers to book multiple dogs simultaneously, ensuring bonded pairs in the shelter can be walked together without system errors.



First-Class Recurring Scheduling

Benefit: Transforms ad-hoc volunteering into predictable routines. Replaces 'I'll see when I'm free' with 'I walk this dog every Tuesday,' drastically reducing kennel anxiety.



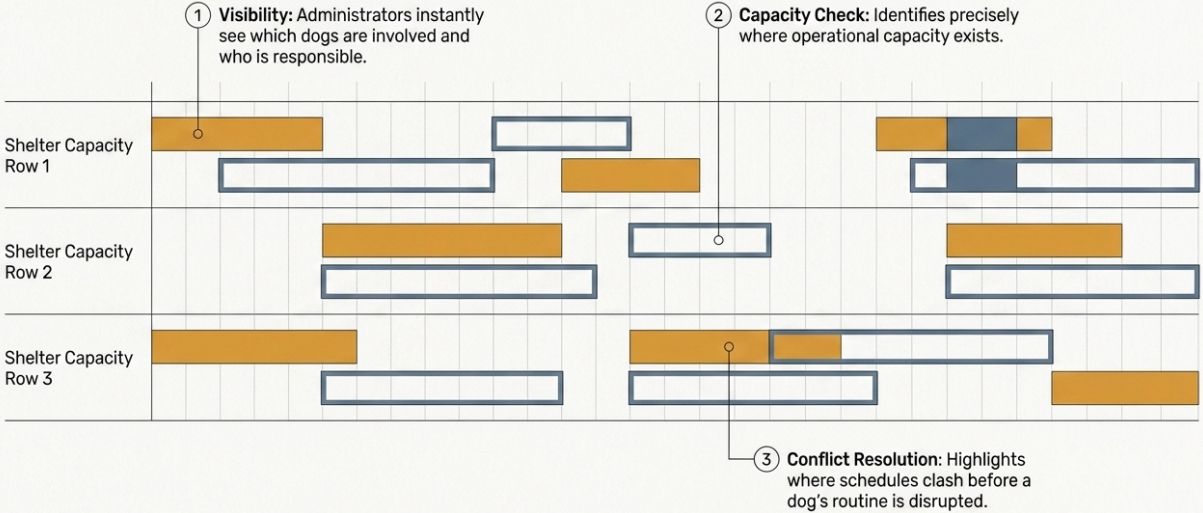
Modification-Tolerant Data Structure

Benefit: Shelter operations are dynamic. When dogs, volunteers, or medical needs change, the system adapts instantly, ensuring no dog's care schedule breaks down.

Gemini Notebook

The Calendar as a Dispatch System

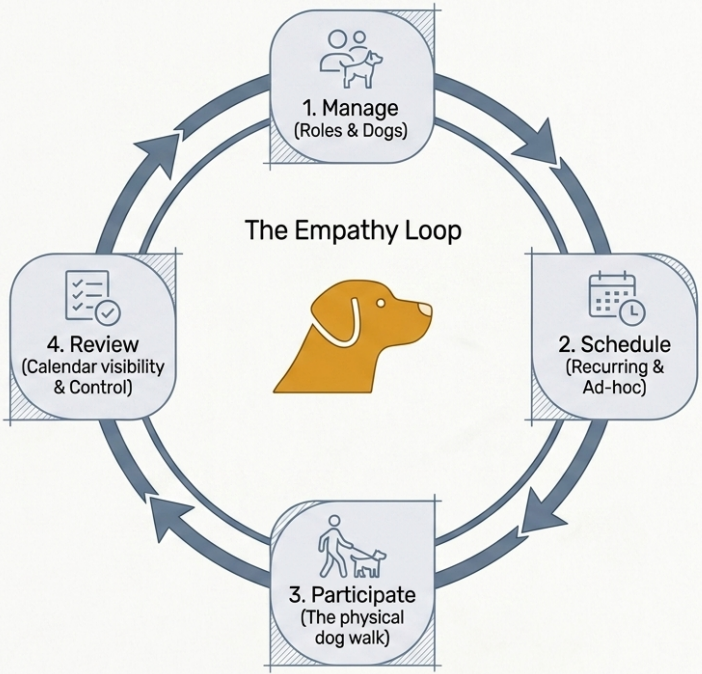
The calendar is not a date picker; it is the organisation's operational timeline.



Gemini Notebook

The MVP Loop: Action Over Administration

Rather than building a bloated animal-management platform with messaging and payments, the prototype ruthlessly prioritises the smallest useful operational loop.
Every feature must answer operational loop.
Every feature must answer one question: Does this help get a dog out of their kennel today?



Gemini Notebook

The Future: Intelligence for Better Welfare

Under-Served Dogs



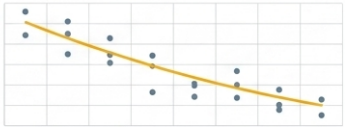
Flagging animals that haven't been walked in 48 hours.

Scheduling Optimisation



Matching historical volunteer capacity to kennel peaks.

Behavioural Tracking



Correlating walking frequency with reduced kennel stress.

The ultimate opportunity is not just better booking. It is gaining total visibility into the relationship between human capacity and animal needs—ensuring no dog is ever left behind.

Gemini Notebook